

MIEF Capstone Course and Project

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Capstone Proposal

Research Background

Many studies have shown a positive relationship between education and political participation. Verba, Schlozman, and Brady (1995) show education as the strongest predictor of civic engagement via skills, resources, and networks. However, the research lacks cross-country validity. In the area of cross-country studies, Zhang (2022) demonstrates that the political regime is a powerful moderator that weakens the effect of education on fostering pro-democratic values in non-free societies. However, it still cannot explain why democracies in East Asia also exhibit lower political participation, even with high levels of education. To address this question, Campante and Chor (2012) demonstrate that education's impact on participation also depends on economic structure, which dampens the effect in skill-intensive economies. In their study, they also include cultural robustness checks using workplace obedience as an indicator of culture, which triggers my interest in exploring the mechanism with culture as a moderator in the relationship between education and political participation.

Different from political regime and economic structure, culture exists beyond the borders of countries. For example, migrants leaving their home country will still be influenced by their original culture. Such nuances can only be observed at the individual level. In this research, I use individual observations from the Wave 7 World Values Survey to study how culture moderates the relationship between education and political participation. My research question is as follows:

Does the effect of education on political participation vary across different cultural backgrounds?

Data and Methodology

I use WVS Wave 7 (2017–2022) cross-national data in this research, which offers abundant cross-country data at the individual level. To measure political participation, I adopt eight indicators: Political Interest (Q199), Frequency of Political Discussion (Q200), Petition (Q209), Boycotts (Q210), Demonstration (Q211), Strike (Q212), Local Vote (Q221), and National Vote (Q222).

The first two measures capture the “soft” participation, which is integrated into one's daily life, while the last measures capture the “hard” participation, which requires additional time and effort to complete, especially the voting behaviors.

For explanatory variables, I use the self-reported Highest education level (Q275) to represent the education level of an individual. Some important child qualities, such as Independence (Q8), Hard work (Q9), Responsibility (Q10), Tolerance and Respect (Q12), Thrift (Q13), Unselfishness (16), and Obedience (Q17), account for cultural difference. To remove as much endogeneity as possible within those cultural variables, I introduce Language spoken at home (Q272) as an instrument for

them, which reflects early-life cultural socialization and is exogenous to adult participation (assigned at birth, no reverse causality).

The WVS data also provide demographic indicators, which are included as control variables, such as age, gender, income, urban/rural, employment, marital status, and religiosity.

As for methodology, I adopt a 2SLS model with language at home as an instrument for obedience. The baseline model is as follows:

First Stage Model:

$$Cul_i = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 Lang_i + \gamma_2 V_i + v_i$$

Second Stage Model:

$$PolPart_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Educ_i + \beta_2 \widehat{Cul}_i + \beta_3 (Educ_i \times \widehat{Cul}_i) + \beta_4 V_i + \epsilon_i$$

Where:

$PolPart_i$ is a vector of dependent variables. As above, eight indicators are used to measure the facets of political participation.

$Educ_i$ represents the highest level of education of individual.

Cul_i is a vector of cultural variables.

$Lang_i$ is the instrument variable used to estimate Cul_i in the first stage, representing the language spoken at home for individual.

$(Educ_i \times Cul_i)$ is the interaction term, which captures the moderating effects of culture on the relationship between education and political participation.

V_i is a vector of control variables, such as age, gender, income, etc.

To test the robustness of the model, I will adapt it by introducing country fixed effects, using subsamples (e.g., East Asia vs. Latin America), and testing the validity of the instrument variable.

Anticipated Results

Through the results, this research aims to explore culture as a moderator in the relationship between education and political participation, and through what channels culture influences the process.